Exile: The Temple Falls

2 Kings 22–25; Jeremiah 29; 31; Daniel 3; 6

The big idea: Judah ignored the prophets, and in 586 BC Babylon burned the temple and carried the people away. Yet God stayed with his exiles and gave his brightest promises in the ashes: a new covenant, a new heart, his Spirit, and an everlasting King. Jesus went into the deepest exile on the cross to bring us home.

Before you meet: Read

2 Kings 25:1–12 | Psalm 137:1–4; Lamentations 3:19–24 | Jeremiah 29:4–14 | Daniel 3:13–28 | Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:26–27

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever moved somewhere you did not want to go, or lost something you thought you would always have? What was that like?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Do not trust in these deceptive words: 'This is the _____ of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD.'" *(Jeremiah 7:4)*

"By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and _____, when we remembered Zion." *(Psalm 137:1)*

"But seek the _____ of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf." *(Jeremiah 29:7)*

"But if _____, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods." *(Daniel 3:18)*

"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their _____." *(Jeremiah 31:33)*

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his _____ never come to an end; they are new every morning." *(Lamentations 3:22–23)*

Discuss

1. Judah trusted that God would never let his own temple fall. What sure things do people trust in place of God himself? *Jeremiah 7:4–11*

2. Psalm 137 asks how to sing the LORD's song in a foreign land. Have you ever felt that way? What helped? *Psalm 137:1–4*

3. God told the exiles to build, plant, and seek the welfare of Babylon. What would it look like for you to seek the good of your city? *Jeremiah 29:4–7*

4. Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego said, But if not. How does the cross show that God is good even when he says no? *Daniel 3:16–18*

5. The new covenant promises forgiveness, a new heart, and the Spirit. Which of these do you most need to believe today? *Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:26–27*

6. Jesus bore God's wrath and cried, My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? How does that change the way you see your own seasons of feeling far from God? *Matthew 27:46; Luke 22:20*

Apply this week

Pray for your town by name each day this week and do one concrete thing for its good. Set a regular time and place for prayer, as Daniel did, and keep it. If you are grieving, read Lamentations 3:19–24 and bring your sorrow to God.

Memory verse

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

Lamentations 3:22–23

Pray

Bring God any sorrow or sense of exile you carry. Thank him that his mercies are new every morning. Thank Jesus for the new covenant in his blood, and ask the Spirit to write God's law on your heart.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 17

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Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Psalm 137:1–4 and Jeremiah 29:4–14 aloud together. Then read Jeremiah 31:31–34.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 3, 5, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Fall of Judah timeline and the Promises in the Ashes table in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 18 (Ezra 1 and 3; Nehemiah 8; Malachi 3–4).

Main points to land

1. Judah ignored God's prophets and trusted the temple building instead of God, until there was no remedy (Jeremiah 7:4; 2 Chronicles 36:15–16).
2. Babylon came in waves (605, 597, 586 BC) and burned the temple. God's glory had already departed (2 Kings 25:9; Ezekiel 10:18–19).
3. In exile God's people were to seek the good of Babylon and stay faithful, as Daniel and his friends did. God himself was their sanctuary (Jeremiah 29:7; Ezekiel 11:16).
4. In the ashes God promised a new covenant, a new heart, his Spirit, and a Son of Man whose kingdom will never end (Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:26–27; Daniel 7:13–14).
5. Jesus bore the Father's wrath as our substitute on the cross, the deepest exile, and established the new covenant in his blood to bring us home (Matthew 27:46; Luke 22:20).

Core doctrine to teach

The Sovereignty of God CORE DOCTRINE 17 OF 26

God rules over all things, including nations, kings, and history. Babylon burned the temple because God sent it as his judgment, and Babylon fell when God said so. Nothing happens outside his plan. Yet God never does evil, and people are still responsible for what they choose. His plan is good. *Daniel 4:34–35; Jeremiah 25:9; Isaiah 46:9–10; Ephesians 1:11; Psalm 115:3*

Answer key (Observe)

1. temple
2. wept
3. welfare
4. not

5. hearts
6. mercies

Questions people will ask

What about Jeremiah 29:11, I know the plans I have for you?
It is a real promise, but read it in context. God spoke it to exiles who were told to settle in Babylon for seventy years, and most of them died there (Jeremiah 29:4–10). His plans for welfare and a future were bigger than one lifetime and are fully kept in Christ. It is not a guarantee that every plan of ours will work out.

Why would God let his own temple be destroyed?
He had warned for centuries through his prophets, and his people kept trusting a building while worshiping idols (Jeremiah 7:4–11; 2 Chronicles 36:15–16). The exile was judgment, but also discipline meant to bring them back. God's presence was never limited to a building (Ezekiel 11:16).

Was the fourth man in the furnace Jesus?
Some Christians have thought so. Nebuchadnezzar called him one like a son of the gods and said God sent his angel (Daniel 3:25, 28). The text does not settle it. The point is clear either way: God did not leave his faithful servants alone in the fire.

What does the end of Psalm 137 mean, with its angry words?
The psalm ends with raw cries for justice from people who had watched their city destroyed. God lets grieving people say such things to him honestly, and he keeps judgment in his own hands (Romans 12:19). It is a prayer of pain, not a command for us to take revenge.

Closing prayer

Father, your mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning. Thank you that you did not abandon your people in exile, and that you gave them promises in the ashes. Thank you for Jesus, who bore your wrath for us on the cross and made the new covenant in his blood. Write your law on our hearts, fill us with your Spirit, and help us seek the good of our cities until you bring us home. Amen.